



WebM project announced at Google I/O 2010

Google and a group of other companies announced WebM, a broadly-backed community effort to develop a world-class media format for the open web, at Google I/O 2010, on the 19th of May.

WebM files consist of video streams compressed with the VP8 video codec, plus audio streams compressed with the Vorbis audio codec, in a file whose structure is based on the Matroska media container. VP8 is a highly efficient video compression technology that was developed by On2 Technologies. Google acquired On2 in February 2010, and has released VP8 under a BSD-style, royalty-free licence.

WebM's appeal stems from the promises of very-high-quality video with great playback performance even on older computers; it is 100 per cent free and open to everyone, and supported on popular video sites like YouTube. WebM video files are meant to play directly in your Web browser using HTML5; no plug-ins are required, but you must install a web browser that supports WebM files. To learn about browsers with WebM support, and how to play YouTube videos in WebM format, visit <http://www.webmproject.org/users/>

Adobe has announced (<http://goo.gl/BJoJ>) that they will "include the VP8 video codec in Flash Player in an upcoming release." Opera's announcement of Labs builds with WebM support, and download links for Windows, Mac and Ubuntu Linux is at <http://goo.gl/11r0>. Mozilla's blog about WebM and VP8 is at <http://goo.gl/SANB>

A developer preview of WebM and VP8, including source code, specs, and encoding tools, is available at www.webmproject.org. The FAQ is at www.webmproject.org/about/faq/



Linux Mint 9 announced

Code-named "Isadora", the release is based on Ubuntu 10.04 LTS "Lucid Lynx", and features version 2.6.32 of the Linux kernel, X.org 7.4 and the 2.30 GNOME desktop environment.

Like Lucid, Isadora is a Long-Term-Support release, and adds several new desktop backgrounds, and a completely rewritten Software Manager, with more than 30,000 available applications. Other changes include a rewritten Desktop Settings tool with additional options like moving the window control buttons to the left (Mac style) or right (traditional) side; the mint4win Wubi-based installer for Windows; a USB image creator; and a new incremental Backup Tool for both data and software selections. Mint is currently the third most popular distribution on DistroWatch.com, behind Ubuntu and Fedora. More information and links at: <http://goo.gl/h9dF>



MPEG-LA-owned patent troll sues smartphone makers

An MPEG-LA subsidiary, MobileMedia Ideas LLC, a clear-cut patent troll, has launched several patent infringement suits earlier this year. The company, whose CEO, Larry Horn, is also CEO of the MPEG-LA, acquired 122 patents from Nokia and Sony, and is now using those patents to sue several smartphone makers, including Apple, HTC, and Research In Motion. MobileMedia Ideas owns patents covering "call handling, speed dial functions, database searches, audio download and playback, and still picture and video processing." More at: <http://goo.gl/3aDN>

Puppy Linux 5.0 and Quirky 1.1 arrive

Puppy Linux version 5.0, code named "Lupu", a.k.a. "Lucid Puppy", is the first release to be based on Ubuntu, and includes several changes over the previous 4.3.x branch. Built using the Woof build system, and based on Ubuntu 10.04 binary packages, the release features the new Quickpet package manager, which allows users to install a number of Linux programs with a single click. Puppy Linux can boot from several types of media, including USB flash drives, hard disk drives and a LiveCD. Built-in tools let you create bootable USB versions and new Puppy CDs, and remaster a new LiveCD with different packages. This release was built by the Puppy community, with Mick Amadio as chief developer and Larry Short as coordinator.

Meanwhile, Puppy Linux founder Barry Kauler has released Quirky 1.1, a bug-fix update of his Linux distribution, which is aimed at developers as a platform for trying out "some quirky ideas." Compared to Puppy, Quirky includes fewer kernel and video drivers, but does include a number of programs from a normal Puppy release.

For more information and links, visit <http://goo.gl/pTiy>

